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Writing assignment 3.

In this assignment I want to talk a little bit about the one recent example of a new technology that caused a lot of problems, which was the Google's new AI search. It started coming out around May 2024, so it's still really new and came out about a year ago. It's called as an AI Overviews. Basically, when you search something on Google now, instead of seeing websites first, you get this big box where AI gives you an answer, before even your search websites appear, so you do not need to be searching for your needed website or questions as that was before. It kind of talks to you like a person would, without any challenges I would say.

At the very beginning it sounded like a great idea, it will be faster and more efficient, you do not need to spend hours for searching the answer to your questions. Everyone likes getting fast answers, right? But pretty quickly, it turned into a big problem for a lot of people, small businesses and etc.

The technology I was mentioning above was Google's AI Overviews. Let's go over what it is before we start going deeper into the information about this new technology. It is like a chatbot or virtual assistant that tries to guess the best answer for you without you needing to click on anything, which does not require your time for searchers and juts provides you with the ready answer. It sounds cool, but it actually caused a lot of disruption in real world.

The big problem was that the AI takes information from other websites and gives it to users without making them click on the actual website, which plays a crucial role for the programmers. Before, when people searched for something, they had to visit different websites to find out more, and get the information that they are looking for and check for its bias and spend hours on it. That helped writers, news sites, bloggers, and small businesses because they got visitors on their websites, which meant that more visitors more ad money or more people buying things from their sites. It kept the internet alive, busier and more interesting I would love to mention.

But now, if Google's AI gives you the answer right away, you don't have to visit those sites anymore, you do not need to be spending your valuable time on these websites and you search. So traffic to websites dropped a lot. For some small sites, their visitors went down by more than 50% in just a few weeks. That's a huge deal. Imagine working hard for years building a blog or small business in internet, and then suddenly half of your customers are gone overnight, just because they are do need to look for any information and search different websites. That's what happened to a lot of people. They lost their hope, their motivation, as more people also means more need on what they were doing.

In fact, according to an article by The Verge published in May 2024, some websites saw their traffic drop by more than 44% after Google launched AI Overviews. This shows how fast and serious the impact was. (Source: The Verge – "Google's AI Overviews Are Killing Site Traffic," May 2024)

Also, the AI made a lot of mistakes. It gave wrong answers, funny answers, and sometimes even dangerous ones. A CNN article even reported that Google's AI told users to "put glue on pizza to make the cheese stick better," which became a huge joke online and made people trust the AI

even less and learn their lesson. (Source: CNN – “Google’s AI Told People to Eat Rocks and Glue Pizza,” May 2024)

So even though the idea behind the technology was to help people, it ended up hurting a lot of regular people, especially the smaller ones who can’t fight back, who can’t protect themselves as needed.

The group that got impacted the most were small content creators, like bloggers, news writers, small businesses, independent shops, and anyone who made money by people visiting their websites.

In class, we talked a lot about how new technology can sometimes replace people or make their jobs useless without even meaning to. This is exactly what happened here. Google’s AI didn’t set out to ruin small websites, but because it answered questions itself, it replaced the need for people to go visit those websites. It made them invisible, not needed anymore.

We also talked about power imbalance about how big tech companies have so much power that small businesses can’t fight back. That’s what affected it as well. Google is so big and important that even if a lot of website owners complain, they can’t really force Google to change anything.

Another group that got hurt were freelance writers and journalists. News websites rely a lot on people clicking their articles. If fewer people visit, they make less money, they get less job opportunities and even need to fire people from their workplace. Some news sites even announced layoffs and cuts after AI Overviews came out. That’s real people losing real jobs, losing their hopes and their work that thy studied for years.

Finally, even users were impacted. We as regular people are also hurt because sometimes the AI gave wrong or made-up answers. If we can't trust what we read, that’s a big problem for everyone, not just businesses.

Google said a few things to try to manage the situation.

First, they said that AI Overviews would still show links to websites, so people could still click through if they wanted. They said they were "supporting the open web" and that they "care about publishers." But just saying that didn’t really fix the problem because most users just read the AI answer and never clicked anything.

Second, they said they would improve the quality of the AI answers. After a lot of people posted bad examples of the AI giving crazy advice (like putting glue on pizza), Google said they were working on it to make it more accurate. They promised that bad answers would happen less often.

Third, Google said they were experimenting with ways to give websites more credit. They talked about new programs where websites could "opt-in" to AI Overviews and maybe get better placement or tracking. But again, this was very small, and it didn’t really help the websites that lost a lot of traffic already.

In short, they mostly just talked about it and promised to make it better later. They didn’t stop the rollout, and they didn’t offer any real compensation or payment to the people who lost traffic and money because of it.

There are a lot of things Google realistically could have done if they really wanted to help.

First, they could have waited longer to launch AI Overviews. They rushed it because they wanted to beat competitors like OpenAI and Microsoft. But if they had waited and tested it more, they could have caught a lot of the bad answers and fixed them first. Taking more time would have helped everybody — users would get better answers, and websites would have had time to adjust.

Second, they could have asked small website owners for feedback before launching it to millions of people. They could have created a small testing group with real bloggers, small business owners, and writers. These people could have told them right away what problems they were seeing. Google has so much money and resources — they easily could have done this.

Third, they could have set up a payment system. Right now, Google makes a lot of money by showing ads and using other people's content to train its AI. It would have been fair to pay a small fee to the websites that contributed information. Even a small payment per answer or per click would have helped a lot of small creators survive.

Fourth, they could have given more visibility to the websites in the AI answers. Instead of just one small link at the bottom, they could have made it bigger and easier to see. They could have encouraged users to still click and read full articles instead of just staying on Google.

Finally, they could have been more honest. When people first complained, Google acted like it wasn't a big deal. But it was a big deal. If they had admitted early on that it wasn't perfect and that small businesses might be hurt, people would have respected them more. Being open and humble would have gone a long way.

Google is one of the richest companies in the world. They could have afforded all of these things without losing much money. But they chose speed and profit over doing it slowly and carefully.

In the end, technology can be really exciting, but it can also cause real damage if it's rushed or not thought through carefully.

AI can help a lot of people — but it can also take away jobs, ruin small businesses, and spread wrong information if we're not careful. Big companies like Google have a lot of power, and with that power comes responsibility.

If they want to stay trusted by the public, they need to slow down sometimes, listen to people, and build things in a way that helps everybody, not just themselves.

Technology should lift people up — not leave them behind.

Works Cited

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